around to me, silently patting me on the back and then exiting. Vini Mahajan, joint secretary in the prime minister's office, one of my friends and well-wishers, told me as we were all walking out of the meeting that such demonstrative behaviour on the part of the prime minister was uncharacteristic and uncommon. I was deeply touched by the prime minister's gesture, which I realized was both an act of commiseration with my plight and an endorsement of my firm stand.

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Criticism against the Reserve Bank

There was broad endorsement in the media of the Reserve Bank's policy response to the crisis although there were some outliers—some saying that the Reserve Bank was doing too much by way of crisis management and others saying that we were doing too little.

In all of this, there were two strands of criticism from the commentariat during those early months which had disturbed me. The first was that I was compromising the Reserve Bank's already fragile autonomy by allowing the government to dictate policy, confirming what some people suspected at the time of my appointment. The second criticism was that the Reserve Bank remained largely uncommunicative even as it was hyperactive on the policy front. The general refrain was that the Reserve Bank's silence was jarring, especially when set against the flurry of comments from almost everyone in Delhi—whether on the inside track or not—about what *should* be done and what *would* be done by way of policy response to the crisis.

There was not much I could do about the criticism on diluting the Reserve Bank's autonomy, not in the short-term anyway. The crisis was a black swan event, and everywhere around the world, governments, central banks and regulators were acting in concert and synchronizing their policy responses. What we were doing in India was no different from the global practice during those anxious and turbulent times. But my credentials were